

Parks Department Meeting July 15th 2025 Part #2

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NYb74OpxUiE
Publication Date	2025-07-16T11:31:02Z
Target Category	muncie_city

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Municipal Meeting Summary Report

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

Omitted: The transcript does not contain a statutory public hearing or committee session held immediately prior to calling the regular meeting to order.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting (pertaining to the Parks Board / Prairie Creek administration) was called to order by the presiding officer, with discussions focusing on park rules, lease compliance, water company coordination, and upcoming budget considerations.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Members Present:** Shannon, Brad, and other participating board members. Staff members identified include Carl, Nikki, and Kelly.
 - **Members Absent:** Not explicitly specified in the transcript.
 - **Presiding Officer:** Brad (implied by call for motions and leadership of discussion).

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** Not explicitly noted in the provided transcript text.
 - **Approval of Minutes:** Not addressed during the transcript excerpt.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **00:00:10 Rules Changes and Lease Updates**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership / Legal team recommendations.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board discussed proposed rule changes stemming from legal recommendations and water company guidance. Key updates include the addition of verbiage regarding the closure of specific sections per board resolution (for public health and safety), the elimination of lease transfers under Section 4D to align with campsite regulations, and compliance updates for ATV and equestrian trails. An amendment was noted specifying that horses are not permitted on equestrian trails.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None recorded during this specific item.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote (with the noted horse trail amendment).
- **00:02:31 West Side Closure (Equestrian and ATV Trails)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership and administration (Carl).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Discussion centered on a request from the water company to close the west side of Prairie Creek Reservoir (including the Indian Hill campsite, equestrian trails, and ATV trails) by the end of the year due to wildlife preservation, runoff, erosion, and water quality concerns. The board debated acting proactively to show good faith rather than waiting until year-end, noting that users had not engaged in misconduct. Concerns were raised about public notification, refunding reservations, and educational grace periods.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:**
 - Unidentified Resident: Asked about the reasoning behind the closure and how information would be distributed.
 - **00:10:18** Christopher Bilbury: Noted that the livestream feed cut out right before the discussion on changes and that meeting room doors were locked, requiring police assistance to gain entry, labeling it effectively a closed-door meeting.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to close the west side effective August 1st, incorporating an educational grace period.
- **00:14:54 Potential Suspension of the Lottery for the 2026 Season**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership.

- **Deliberation Summary:** The board discussed suspending the campsite and dock lottery for the 2026 season as a precautionary measure. Because the water company has not yet provided an official carrying capacity number for the lake, board members agreed it would be imprudent to hold a lottery and fill campsites for the following year only to face mandatory capacity cuts later.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote to suspend the lottery for the 2026 season.
 - **00:17:58 Prairie Creek Budget, Rate Review, and Winter Storage**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership and Carl (Administration / City Controller).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board reviewed year-to-date and past-year budget documents provided by the city controller ahead of budget season. Given the anticipated reduction in capacity from the west side closure, the board discussed proactive rate reviews for docks, campsites, events, and launch fees (such as potential electrical stipends or dock/launch fee adjustments) during the upcoming August meeting. Winter storage policies for the upcoming season were also flagged for future evaluation.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Addressed during Open Public Comment.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational discussion; no formal vote recorded on budget figures or rate changes during this segment.
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:21:34 Unidentified Resident:**
 - Addressed multiple topics:
 1. Noted that overgrowth on the banks and rock edges at Prairie Creek was severe compared to previous years, making fishing access difficult.
 2. Reported that spring fishing had been oddly poor/dry.
 3. Brought forward an inquiry from the Whittaker neighborhood and arts and culture council regarding the potential refurbishment or replacement of the deteriorating neighborhood sign located near a planned art installation at the Buy Center.
 - **Board Response:** Board members acknowledged the fishing and overgrowth concerns (tying erosion control back to water company policies) and discussed park signage conditions across the city, noting that park entry signs are generally in need of upgrades as part of future beautification and budget planning.
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6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**

- Staff (Nikki, Kelly, Carl, and city media teams) were tasked with pushing out public notifications, social media updates, and website notices regarding the August 1st west side closure and educational grace period.
 - Future budget feedback and park beautification funding were briefly discussed in coordination with administrative needs and grant alignments.
 - **Adjournment:** Approved by Voice Vote to adjourn the meeting.
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